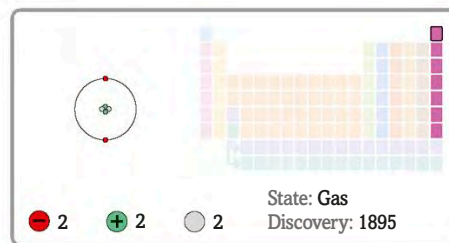
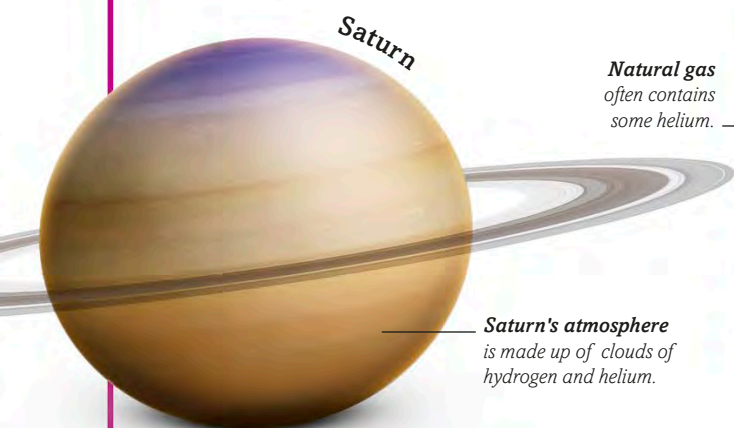


2 He Helium



Forms



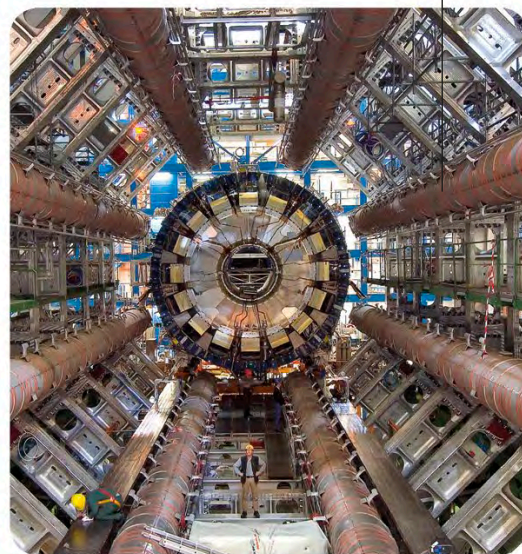
Natural gas often contains some helium.



Gas flare rig

Uses

*A **particle accelerator** is a machine that smashes atoms together: this one uses liquid helium to cool its parts.*



Large Hadron Collider, CERN, Switzerland

Helium-cooled MRI scanner



Helium is the second lightest element after hydrogen. This transparent gas was first discovered in 1868 by Sir William Ramsay, a Scottish chemist. Today, we know that a quarter of all the atoms in the Universe are helium. It is one of the main gases in the atmospheres of

giant gas planets, such as **Saturn**. Being so light, however, helium is very rare on Earth: it escapes from our atmosphere into space. It was not until 1895 that chemists managed to collect a sample of helium gas coming from uraninite, a radioactive uranium mineral. Today, helium is